

Indicative System Prices

AMD

Component	Model	Price (Rs)
Processor	Athlon 64 3200+(939)	9400
Motherboard	MSI RS480M2-IL	5395
RAM	Transcend 512MB DDR400	2500
Hard Disk	Seagate Barracuda 80GB (7200RPM)	2700
Floppy Drive	Sony	300
DVD Combo Drive	Lite-On DVD Combo drive	2450
Monitor (15/17 inch)	LG	4650/5650
Keyboard	Logitech	300
Mouse(Ball/Optical)	Logitech	300/500
Cabinet	Kobian	1200
Total		28895

If you choose a socket 754 board, such as the TUL A480A7-VF then you can go for Athlon 64 2800+ (754) costing Rs 5200. Total System Cost: Rs 24395. If you go for a board without on board graphics like the Winfast NF4K8MC, then you will need to pay Rs 3500 for XFX Geforce 6200 256 MB (TC) PCIE graphics card. Total System Cost: Rs 32750

Intel

Processor	Intel P4 2.8 (LGA 775)	6750
Motherboard	Mercury Pi915GVM	5000
RAM	Transcend 512MB DDR400	2500
Hard Disk	Seagate Barracuda 80GB (7200RPM)	2700
DVD Combo Drive	Lite-On DVD Combo drive	2450
Monitor (15/17 inch)	LG	4650/5700
Keyboard	Logitech	300
Mouse(Ball/Optical)	Logitech	300/500
Cabinet	Kobian	1200
Total		25550

If you choose our silver winner Gigabyte GA-8IG1000-G (socket 478) then you can go in for the P4 2.4 (478 socket) processor costing Rs 5650 and your total system cost would then be Rs 23650

Conclusion

With the various flip-flops in the scores, we had an interesting time trying to come up with a winner.

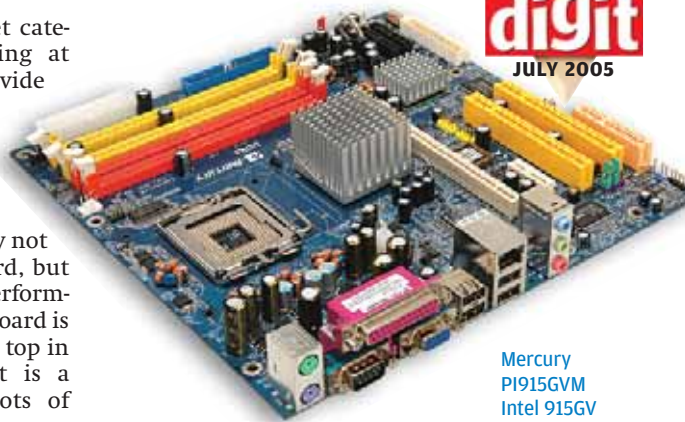
Since this is a budget category and we are looking at boards which should provide all onboard solutions including video, the Digit Best Buy Gold award goes to the Mercury Pi915GVM-V.

This board is certainly not the best-performing board, but then we are not in the performance category—plus the board is near the top if not at the top in almost all our tests. It is a balanced board with lots of

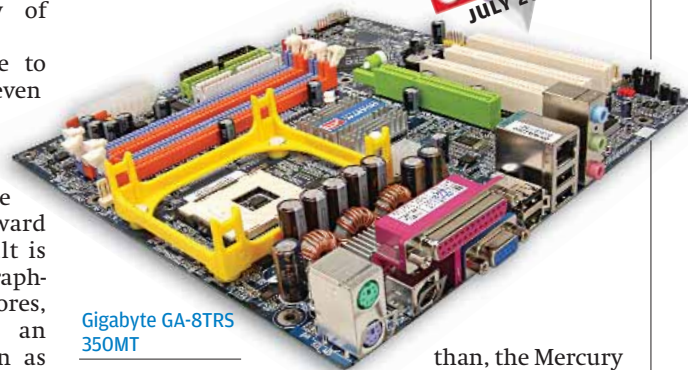
features, and since it is PCIe-based and also supports LGA 775, you will have plenty of upgrade options.

We would like to clarify that even though in terms of pure scores logged, the Foxconn *should* be the 'Gold Award Winner', the result is clearly due to its graphics performance scores, which would be an unfair comparison as the Foxconn board had a 6200 graphics card on it. On all other aspects, our winner is neck and neck with the Foxconn, so the Mercury board was declared the winner.

What you must keep in mind is that the Foxconn motherboard does not have onboard video, so if you don't mind spending a little extra on the additional graphics card, we would absolutely recommend this board, as in all other aspects, it is on par with, if not better



Mercury
Pi915GVM
Intel 915GV



Gigabyte GA-8TR3
350MT

than, the Mercury Pi915GVM-V.

The Digit 'Best Buy Silver' award goes to Gigabyte 8TR3-350MT. This board is a consistent performer, and at the moment is a good buy. However, we would also like to point out that it is not entirely advisable to buy this board as it is based on socket 478, and Intel has stopped manufacturing processors for that socket. Also, this board is based on an older chipset and would not allow you to upgrade to a PCIe-based graphics card in the future.

If you want a commendable performer with a decent price tag and future upgradeability, you should consider the HIS RS400. This board is an LGA 775 board and supports PCIe.

It is amazing what the entry level boards of today have as standard features. If the trend continues, in a year's time we might even see SLI and dual-core support being offered for Rs 5,000 or less! With the advent of Intel Extreme Graphics 2 and ATi's onboard graphics provisions, you are no longer limited to playing arcade games on entry level PCs.

You can now go and buy some of the entry-level games (read high-end games of yesterday, such as Unreal Tournament 2003!) and enjoy them without the need of an additional 3D graphics card.

The choices and options are immense, and the prices are extremely low. Now you need not think ten times before going in for an upgrade, as the features and prices on these boards will give you decent performance at an extremely low cost.

May this trend continue! ☑

varun_dubey@thinkdigit.com
jayesh_limaye@thinkdigit.com

Contact Sheet

Motherboards

Brand	Company	Telephone	E-mail	Web site
Aopen	Xserve India (Pvt) Ltd.	080-5113 1001	info@xserves.com	www.aopen.com
ASRock	Abacus Peripherals Pvt. Ltd	022-56923941/44/45	ajain@abacusperipherals.com	www.asrock.com
ASUS	ASUSTeK Computer Inc.	022-56490048	info_india@asus.com.tw	www.asus.com
Elitegroup	Cyberstar	022-28386711/13	navin@cyberstarindia.com	www.ecsusa.com
Foxconn	Mediatech India	022-26361111	digit@mediatechindia.com	www.foxconnchannel.com
Gigabyte	Gigabyte Technology (India) Ltd.	022-26526696	sales@gigabyte.in	www.giga-byte.com
HIS	Maxtone Electronics	022-23016468	maxtone@vsnl.com	www.maxtone.com
Krypton	Priya Ltd	022 5663199/97	sejal.shah@priyagroup.com	www.priyagroup.com
Mercury	Kobian ECS India Pvt Ltd	022-23020767 / 774	mumbai@kobian.com	www.kobian.com
MSI	Tirupati Enterprices	033-22251192	mail@tirupati.net	www.msi.com.iw
TUL	Mediatech India	011-5151 1234	digit@mediatechindia.com	www.tul.com.tw
Winfast	Mediatech India	022-26361111	digit@mediatechindia.com	www.leadtek.com